

What is an argument and how to develop an argument in Academic Writing

Structure of Academic Writing

Introduction→ Body→ Conclusion

Intention Statement

Scope

Field (locate the paper)

How to open? (Generic-Specific balance)

Internal Coherence

Argument Sentence

Declaration upfront and then bit-by-bit establishment of the declared argument (Step by Step approach)

Claim your claims! (*Meta-statements*)

Signposting (always show how your minor arguments are related to the major ones)

Transition Sentences

Flow (let the sub-points be properly inter-connected)

Research is **showing how** you arrived at an argument rather than simply positing **what the argument is!** [the HOW is more important than the WHAT]

The **PROCESS** counts!

Writing with the academic target audience in mind!

What knowledge should I assume on the audience's side?

Lit Survey/Review

What to survey?

Survey of the relevant lit in the field or everything in the field?

Summary or point of departure?

How to make sure that my own argument does not get clouded out by the various secondary literatures I am citing?

Survey of major trends in the field is good to start with until you come to your major research questions

Try and think about the relevance of the lit you are reviewing in relation to your research questions

Research as a non-obvious contribution to knowledge

Identifying research gap in the field

What is your paper/thesis's unique contribution to the field?

Is it opening up new questions that will progress the field further?

Disagreements with the existing research in the field

You can disagree respectfully without rubbishing the other!

What are your research questions that seek to address the research gap?

What's your method?

How are you planning to divide the work? (section/chapter divisions)

What does the reader know?

Am I being inaccessible in language/expression/style?

Is it too technical?

Use of jargons (explain each jargon the first time you use it: at least a working definition in brackets)

It is advisable to **imagine** if the reader will get the point that you think you are getting as you write it out. What is clear to you may not be clear to the reader! You may be thinking from inside your cognitive prism. It is good to break that prism and put yourself in the position of the reader to check if they would be able to make sense of your arguments.

Ease the reader into the piece rather than opening heavily.

What are research questions?

How to arrive at them?

Literature review→ gap

Narrowing down

What is an argument?

A knowledge-claim

A response to the research questions

Is an argument an opinion?

Can it always be proven?

Proof v/s logical consistency

Can an argument be creative?

Statement of the argument

How? Step by step establishment

Do not summarize alone, you need to analyze data/text.

What are your findings?

Thesis is an argument and not just research questions. It is important to be able to generate an argument statement that addresses your questions and possibly resolves them or weaves them in a critical direction

Explication v/s originality

Interpretation/Analysis

Argumentativeness

Developing a Thesis:

1. Describe your experiment or analyze your primary data/text/problem
1. Contextualize it in the field, do a lit review of the identified problem, if needed.
1. Announce your own narrative/argument on the object of analysis (experiment/data/text)
1. Anticipate the main thesis in the introduction itself: declare it upfront.
1. Keep signposting the central thesis throughout the piece
1. Try and think of counterarguments to your main argument/thesis

The **topic** of an article and its **thesis/argument/claim** are different.

A thesis is not your research question. It's an answer or a response to the research questions.

For example the incompleteness theorems may be your topic but what you argue about them is a **narrative** you build about the theorems. ***You claim that the theorem shows this that has not been developed fully as one of its implications.*** This is a claim/an argument/a thesis.

A paper may have **multiple claims/arguments** but it is always a good idea to think about **how they relate to one another**. If they are not linked properly, the paper may read incoherent and more like a series of **orthogonal claims** than **one posited argument**.

In other words, you have to make all the claims work together as much as possible and think through an **overarching claim that can house most of the sub-claims within its fold**.

What is a thesis statement?

A thesis statement:

- tells the reader how you will interpret the significance of the subject matter under discussion.
- is a road map for the paper; in other words, it tells the reader what to expect from the rest of the paper.
- directly answers the question asked of you. A thesis is an interpretation of a question or subject, not the subject itself. The subject, or topic, of an essay might be World War II or Moby Dick; a thesis must then offer a way to understand the war or the novel.
- makes a claim that others might dispute.
- is usually a single sentence near the beginning of your paper (most often, at the end of the first paragraph) that presents your argument to the reader. The rest of the paper, the body of the essay, gathers and organizes evidence that will persuade the reader of the logic of your interpretation.

If your assignment asks you to take a position or develop a claim about a subject, you may need to convey that position or claim in a thesis statement near the beginning of your draft. The assignment may not explicitly state that you need a thesis statement because your instructor may assume you will include one. When in doubt, ask your instructor if the assignment requires a thesis statement. When an assignment asks you to analyze, to interpret, to compare and contrast, to demonstrate cause and effect, or to take a stand on an issue, it is likely that you are being asked to develop a thesis and to support it persuasively. (Check out our [handout on understanding assignments](#) for more information.)

From University of North Carolina Chapel Hill Writing Centre website

How do I know if my thesis is strong?

If there's time, run it by your instructor or make an appointment at the Writing Center to get some feedback. Even if you do not have time to get advice elsewhere, you can do some thesis evaluation of your own. **When reviewing your first draft and its working thesis, ask yourself the following:**

- **Do I answer the question?** Re-reading the question prompt after constructing a working thesis can help you fix an argument that misses the focus of the question. If the prompt isn't phrased as a question, try to rephrase it. For example, "Discuss the effect of X on Y" can be rephrased as "What is the effect of X on Y?"
- **Have I taken a position that others might challenge or oppose?** If your thesis simply states facts that no one would, or even could, disagree with, it's possible that you are simply providing a summary, rather than making an argument.
- **Is my thesis statement specific enough?** Thesis statements that are too vague often do not have a strong argument. If your thesis contains words like "good" or "successful," see if you could be more specific: why is something "good"; what specifically makes something "successful"?
- **Does my thesis pass the "So what?" test?** If a reader's first response is likely to be "So what?" then you need to clarify, to forge a relationship, or to connect to a larger issue.
- **Does my essay support my thesis specifically and without wandering?** If your thesis and the body of your essay do not seem to go together, one of them has to change. It's okay to change your working thesis to reflect things you have figured out in the course of writing your paper. Remember, always reassess and revise your writing as necessary.
- **Does my thesis pass the "how and why?" test?** If a reader's first response is "how?" or "why?" your thesis may be too open-ended and lack guidance for the reader. See what you can add to give the reader a better take on your position right from the beginning.

Signposting the argument

Transition Sentence

The College of Saint Rose Writing Center, 2012

Transition Sentences



Why do I need to use transition sentences?

- They bring out the ***logical relation*** between ideas, sentences, paragraphs, and sections of a paper. They can help readers understand how sentences and paragraphs work together to lead to a larger idea.
- They provide the reader with ***directions*** for how to piece together your ideas into a logically coherent argument. You cannot assume that your readers know everything that you know, so sometimes you need to lead them through your paper. Transition words and sentences can serve as stepping stones.
- Transition sentences make your writing sound less choppy, jumpy, or abrupt. They help establish ***organizational flow***.

Forms of Topic Sentences

Sometimes topic sentences are actually two or even three sentences long. If the first makes a claim, the second might reflect on that claim, explaining it further. Think of these sentences as asking and answering two critical questions: How does the phenomenon you're discussing operate? Why does it operate as it does?

Signposts

Signposts operate as topic sentences for whole sections in an essay. (In longer essays, sections often contain more than a single paragraph.) They inform a reader that the essay is taking a turn in its argument: delving into a related topic such as a counter-argument, stepping up its claims with a complication, or pausing to give essential historical or scholarly background. Because they reveal the architecture of the essay itself, signposts remind readers of what the essay's stakes are: what it's about, and why it's being written.

Pivots. Topic sentences don't always appear at the beginning of a paragraph. When they come in the middle, they indicate that the paragraph will change direction, or "pivot." This strategy is particularly useful for dealing with counter-evidence: a paragraph starts out conceding a point or stating a fact ("Psychologist Sharon Hymer uses the term 'narcissistic friendship' to describe the early stage of a friendship like the one between Celie and Shug"); after following up on this initial statement with evidence, it then reverses direction and establishes a claim ("Yet ... this narcissistic stage of Celie and Shug's relationship is merely a transitory one. Hymer herself concedes . . . "). The pivot always needs a signal, a word like "but," "yet," or "however," or a longer phrase or sentence that indicates an about-face. It often needs more than one sentence to make its point.